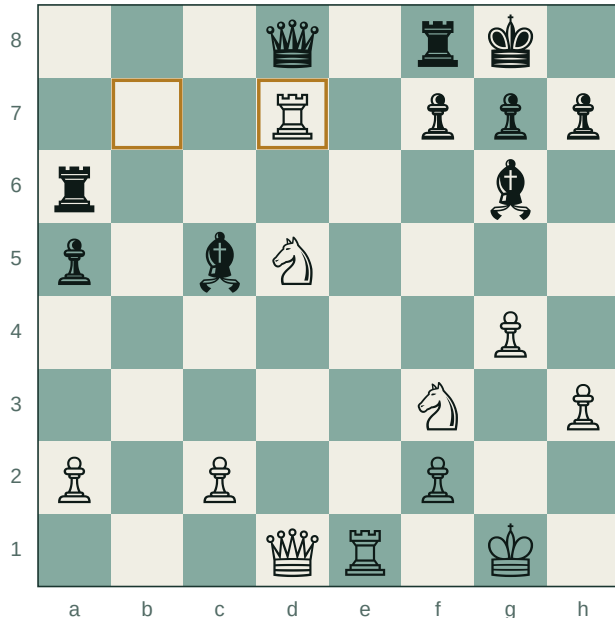


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 18

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 18.Rd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18...Qxd7 19. Nf6+ Rxf6 20. Qxd7 Rxf3

18...Qxd7 The queen captures the rook on d7. Recorded reply: **19.Nf6+**.

19...Rxf6 The rook captures the knight on f6. Recorded reply: **20.Qxd7**.

20...Rxf3 The rook captures the knight on f3.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from -1 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: pawn on f2.